# Tabaqat al-Umam

## (Categories of Nations)

كِتَابُ طَبَقَاتِ الْأُمَمِ

**Bilingual Edition**

Arabic Text • English Translation

By

**Abu al-Qasim Sa'id ibn Ahmad al-Andalusi**

(d. 462 AH / 1070 CE)

لِلْقَاضِي أَبِي الْقَاسِمِ صَاعِدِ بْنِ أَحْمَدَ بْنِ صَاعِدٍ الْأَنْدَلُسِيِّ

الْمُتَوَفَّى سَنَةَ ٤٦٢ هـ / ١٠٧٠ م

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Digital bilingual scholarly edition

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## Editor's Introduction

### تَوْطِئَةُ الْمُحَقِّقِ

كِتَابُ طَبَقَاتِ الْأُمَمِ أَحَدُ الْكُتُبِ النَّادِرَةِ الَّتِي نَعَرَّضُ فِيهَا كَتَبَةُ الْعَرَبِ لِوَصْفِ الْعُلُومِ بَيْنَ الْأُمَمِ الَّتِي سَبَقَتْ عَهْدَهُمْ، وَإِنْ لَمْ يَبْلُغْ صَاحِبُهُ فِي ذَلِكَ شَأْوَ كِتَابِ الْفِهْرِسْتِ لِأَبِي الْفَرَجِ ابْنِ الدَّمِيمِ إِلَّا أَنَّهُ جَمَعَ عِدَّةَ فَوَائِدَ تَدُلُّ عَلَى نَشَاطٍ فِي الْبَحْثِ وَعَلَى رَغْبَةٍ فِي التَّحْصِيلِ وَدَقَّةَ نَظَرٍ فِي التَّنْوِينِ، وَكَانَ أَهْلُ الْأَنْدَلُسِ يَفْتَخِرُونَ بِهِ وَبِرُؤُوسِ أَهْلِ الشَّرْقِ.

وَقَدْ ذَكَرَ ابْنُ الْأَبَّارِ فِي كِتَابِ التَّكْمِلَةَ لِكِتَابِ الصِّلَةَ (٢ : ٤٦٣ طَبْعَةُ بَجْرَيْطَ) عَنْ عَبْدِ اللهِ بْنِ مُحَمَّدِ بْنِ مَرْزُوقٍ الْيَحْصَبِيِّ أَنَّهُ قَدَّمَ الْإِسْكَنْدَرِيَّةَ رَوَى هَذَا الْكِتَابَ لِأَبِي طَاهِرٍ السَّلَفِيِّ.

وَمِمَّنْ عَرَّفُوا هَذَا الْكِتَابَ فِي الشَّرْقِ أَبُو الْفَرَجِ غْرِيغُورِيُوسَ ابْنُ الْعِبْرِيِّ فَإِنَّهُ نَقَلَ عَنْهُ فِي كِتَابِ تَارِيخِ مُخْتَصَرِ الدُّوَلِ نَبْذَتَيْنِ مُفِيدَتَيْنِ فِي الْعَرَبِ وَعُلُومِهِمْ، وَكَذَلِكَ عَرَفَهُ الْحَاجُّ خَلِيفَةُ فَذَكَرَهُ مِرَارًا فِي كِتَابِهِ كَشْفِ الظُّنُونِ فَدَعَا تَارَةً التَّعْرِيفُ بِطَبَقَاتِ الْأُمَمِ وَقَالَ فِي وَصْفِهِ إِنَّهُ كِتَابٌ صَغِيرُ الْحَجْمِ كَثِيرُ النَّفْعِ.

وَهِيَ مَكْتُوبَةٌ بِخَطٍّ جَلِيٍّ شَبِيهٍ بِالْقَلَمِ الْفَارِسِيِّ عَلَى وَرَقٍ صَفِيقٍ ضَارِبٍ إِلَى الصَّفْرَةِ وَمُجَلَّدَةٌ تَجْلِيدًا مُتْقَنًا بِجِلْدٍ وَرَقٍ مُلَوَّنٍ ذَهَبِيٌّ عَلَى الْوَجْهَيْنِ مَعَ لِسَانٍ مِثْلِهِمَا زَيْنَةٌ.

أَمَّا الْمُؤَلِّفُ فَلَا نَعْلَمُ أَقَلَّ مِنْ أَمْرِهِ، وَهَذِهِ تَرْجَمَتُهُ كَمَا رَوَاهَا ابْنُ بَشْكُوَالٍ فِي كِتَابِ الصِّلَةَ (طَبْعَةُ بَجْرَيْطَ ص ٢٣٤):

<<صَاعِدُ بْنُ أَحْمَدَ بْنِ عَبْدِ الرَّحْمَنِ بْنِ مُحَمَّدِ بْنِ صَاعِدٍ التَّغْلِبِيُّ الْقَاضِي بِكُنْيَةِ أَبِي الْقَاسِمِ وَأَصْلُهُ مِنْ قُرْطُبَةَ رُوِيَ عَنْ أَبِي مُحَمَّدِ بْنِ حَزْمٍ وَالْفَتْحِ بْنِ قَاسِمٍ وَأَبِي الْوَلِيدِ الْوَقْشِيِّ وَغَيْرِهِمْ، وَاسْتَقْضَاهُ الْأَمِيرُ يَحْيَى بْنُ ذِي النُّونِ بِطُلَيْطَلَةَ وَكَانَ مِنْ أَهْلِ الْمَعْرِفَةِ وَالذَّكَاءِ وَالرِّوَايَةِ، وُلِدَ بِالْمَرِيَّةِ فِي سَنَةِ ٤٢٠ (هـ = ١٠٣٩ م) وَتُوُفِّيَ بِطُلَيْطَلَةَ فِي شَوَّالِ سَنَةِ ٤٦٢ هـ = ١٠٧٠

### [Editor's Introduction]

*Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam* (The Book of the Categories of Nations) is one of the rare works in which an Arab writer describes the sciences among the nations that preceded his era. Although its author did not reach the level of Abu al-Faraj ibn al-Damimi in his *Fihrist*, he nevertheless collected numerous useful facts that demonstrate his research activity, his desire for knowledge, and his precision in observation. The people of al-Andalus used to boast of him and of the heads of the East.

Ibn al-Abbār mentions in his *Takmila* to the *Silah* (2:463, Bajarid edition) on the authority of Abd Allah ibn Muhammad ibn Marzūq al-Yahṣibí that he transmitted this book to Abu Tahir al-Salafí.

Among those who knew this book in the East was Abu al-Faraj Grigorius ibn al-ʿIbrī, for he quoted from it in his *History of the Dynasties* two useful excerpts concerning the Arabs and their sciences. Likewise, al-Hājj Khalīfa knew it and mentioned it several times in his *Kashf al-Zunun*: at one point calling it *Taʿrīf bi-Tabaqat al-Umam*, and describing it as a small book of great benefit.

[Manuscript Description:] The manuscript is written in a clear hand resembling Persian script, on thick paper tending toward yellow, and bound with skillful binding in colored gold paper on both sides with a matching tongue as ornament.

As for the author, we know no less than what Ibn Bashkuwal narrated in his *Silah* (Bajarid edition, p. 234):

"Saʿid ibn Ahmad ibn ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn Muḥammad ibn Saʿid al-Taghlabī, the judge with the kunya Abu al-Qāsim, originally from Cordoba, transmitted from Abu Muḥammad ibn Ḥazm, al-Fatḥ ibn Qāsim, Abu al-Walīd al-Waqshī, and others. The amir Yahyā ibn Dhī al-Nūn appointed him as judge of Tulaytula (Toledo). He was a man of knowledge, intelligence, and transmission. He was born in al-Mariyya (Almeria) in 420 AH (1039 CE) and died in Tulaytula while serving as its judge in Shawwal of the year 462 AH (1070 CE)."

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## Chapter One: The Ancient Nations

### الْبَابُ الْأَوَّلُ : الْأُمَمُ الْقَدِيمَةُ

بِسْمِ اللهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

رَبِّ يَسِّرْ

قَالَ الْقَاضِي أَبُو الْقَاسِمِ صَاعِدُ بْنُ أَحْمَدَ بْنِ صَاعِدٍ رَحِمَهُ اللهُ تَعَالَى: اعْلَمْ أَنَّ جَمِيعَ النَّاسِ فِي مَشَارِقِ الْأَرْضِ وَمَغَارِبِهَا وَجَنُوبِهَا وَشَمَالِهَا وَإِنْ كَانُوا نَوْعًا وَاحِدًا يَتَمَيَّزُونَ بِثَلَاثَةِ أَشْيَاءَ: بِالْأَخْلَاقِ وَالصُّوَرِ وَاللُّغَاتِ.

وَزَعَمَ مَنْ عُنِّيَ بِأَخْبَارِ الْأُمَمِ وَبَحَثَ عَنْ سَائِرِ الْأَجْيَالِ وَفَحَصَ عَنْ طَبَقَاتِ الْقُرُونِ أَنَّ النَّاسِ كَانُوا فِي سَالِفِ الدُّهُورِ وَقَبْلَ تَشَعُّبِ الْقَبَائِلِ وَافْتِرَاقِ اللُّغَاتِ سَبْعَ أُمَمٍ.

**(الْأُمَّةُ الْأُولَى)** الْفُرْسُ وَكَانَ مَسْكَنُهَا فِي الْوَسَطِ الْمَعْمُورِ وَحَدُّ بِلَادِهَا مِنَ الْجِبَالِ الَّتِي فِي شَمَالِ الْعِرَاقِ بِعَقَبَةِ حُلْوَانَ وَالَّذِي فِيهِ الْأَنْجَهَاتُ وَالْكُرَجُ وَالدُّسْتُورُ وَهَمَدَانَ وَقُمَّ وَقَاشَانَ وَغَيْرِهَا مِنَ الْبِلَادِ إِلَى أَرْمِينِيَةَ وَالْبَابِ الْمُتَّصِلِ بِبَحْرِ أَذْرَبِيجَانَ وَطُبَرِسْتَانَ وَمُولْتَانَ وَالْبِيلَقَانَ وَأَرْزَنَ وَالشَّابَرَانَ وَالرِّيِّ وَالطَّالِقَانَ وَجُرْجَانَ إِلَى بِلَادِ خُرَاسَانِ.

**[Chapter One: The Ancient Nations]**

*In the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate.*

*O Lord, make it easy!*

The judge Abu al-Qāsim Saʿīd ibn Aḥmad ibn Saʿīd—may God the Exalted have mercy on him—said: Know that all people in the East and West of the Earth, in its South and North, though they are one species, are distinguished by three things: by their moral character, their physical forms, and their languages.

Those who have concerned themselves with the reports of nations and investigated the various generations, and examined the categories of ages, say that in earliest times, before the branching of tribes and the divergence of languages, there were seven nations.

**The First Nation**: The Persians. Their dwelling was in the middle of the inhabited world. Their lands include the mountains in the north of Iraq, the region of Hulwan, and the area containing the Anjahāt, Kuraj, Dustūr, Hamadān, Qumm, Qāshān, and other lands extending to Armenia, the Gate connecting to the Sea of Azerbaijan, Tabaristān, Multān, Bilāqān, Arzan, Shāborān, al-Rayy, Tāliqān, and Jurjān, to the lands of Khurāsān.

## Chapter Two: Science in India

### الْعِلْمُ فِي الْهِنْدِ

وَلِبُعْدِ الْهِنْدِ مِنْ بِلَادِنَا وَاعْتِرَاضِ الْمَوَانِعِ بَيْنَنَا وَبَيْنَهُمْ فَلَمْ نَأْلَفْهُمْ فَلَمْ يَصِلْ إِلَيْنَا طَرَفٌ مِنْ عُلُومِهِمْ وَلَا وَرَدَتْ عَلَيْنَا إِلَّا نُبَذٌ مِنْ مَذَاهِبِهِمْ وَلَا سَمِعْنَا إِلَّا بِالْقَلِيلِ مِنْ عِلْمِهِمْ.

فَمِنْ مَذَاهِبِ الْهِنْدِ فِي عُلُومِ النُّجُومِ الْمَذَاهِبُ الثَّلَاثَةُ الْمَشْهُورَةُ عَنْهُمْ وَهُوَ مَذْهَبُ السِّنْدِ هِنْدٌ وَمَذْهَبُ الْأَزْدِيجِ وَمَذْهَبُ الْأَرْكَنْدِ وَلَمْ يَصِلْ إِلَيْنَا مِنْهُمْ عَلَى التَّحْصِيلِ إِلَّا مَذْهَبُ السِّنْدِ هِنْدٌ وَهُوَ الْمَذْهَبُ الَّذِي تَقَلَّدَهُ جَمَاعَةٌ مِنَ الْإِسْلَامِ وَالْقُوَّامُ فِيهِ الْأَزْيَاجُ كَمُحَمَّدِ بْنِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ الْفَزَارِيِّ وَحَبَشِ بْنِ عَبْدِ اللهِ الْبَغْدَادِيِّ وَمُحَمَّدِ بْنِ مُوسَى الْخَوَارِزْمِيِّ وَالْحُسَيْنِ بْنِ مُحَمَّدٍ الْمَعْرُوفِ بِابْنِ الْآدَمِيِّ وَغَيْرِهِمْ. وَتَفْسِيرُ السِّنْدِ هِنْدٍ <<الدَّهْرُ الدَّاهِرُ>> كَذَلِكَ حَكَى الْحُسَيْنُ بْنُ الْآدَمِيِّ فِي زِيجِهِ.

**[فَصْلٌ]**

وَأَمَّا أَصْحَابُ السِّنْدِ هِنْدٍ فَإِنَّهُمْ وَافَقُوا أَنْ لَا عَدَدَ مَدَّةِ الْعَالَمِ فَإِنَّ مَذْهَبَهُمُ الَّتِي ذَكَرُوهَا أَنَّ الْكَوَاكِبَ وَأَوْجَاتِهَا وَجُوزَهَرَاتِهَا مُجْتَمِعَتْ فِي رَأْسِ الْحَمَلِ فَمُنْذُ ذَلِكَ الْأَمْرِ أَبْدَأَتْ حَرَكَاتُ الْكَوَاكِبِ وَالْأَوْجَاتِ وَالْجَوْزَهَرَاتِ فِي الْأَرْضِ وَبَقِيَ الْعَالَمُ السُّفْلَى خَرَابًا دَهْرًا طَوِيلًا حَتَّى تَتَفَرَّقَ الْكَوَاكِبُ وَالْأَوْجَاتُ وَالْجَوْزَهَرَاتُ فِي الْبُرُوجِ فَإِذَا كَانَ كَذَلِكَ بَدَأَتْ حَالَةُ الْعَالَمِ السُّفْلِيِّ إِلَى الْأَمْرِ الْأَوَّلِ هَكَذَا أَبَدًا إِلَى غَيْرِ غَايَةٍ عِنْدَهُمْ. وَلِكُلِّ وَاحِدٍ مِنَ الْكَوَاكِبِ وَالْأَوْجَاتِ وَالْجَوْزَهَرَاتِ أَدْوَارٌ مَا فِي هَذِهِ الْمُدَّةِ الَّتِي هِيَ عِنْدَهُمْ مَدَّةُ الْعَالَمِ قَدْ ذَكَرْتُهَا.

### [Science in India]

Because of the distance of India from our lands and the obstacles between us and them, we have not become familiar with them. No portion of their sciences has reached us, nothing has come to us but fragments of their doctrines, and we have heard only a little of their knowledge.

Among the doctrines of the Indians in the science of astrology, three doctrines are famous among them: the doctrine of Sindhind, the doctrine of the Āzīj, and the doctrine of Arkand. Only the doctrine of Sindhind has reached us in a complete form. It was followed by a group of Muslims, and those who established it were al-Azyāj such as Muḥammad ibn Ibrāhīm al-Fazārī, Ḥabash ibn ʿAbd Allāh al-Baghdādī, Muḥammad ibn Mūsā al-Khwārizmī, al-Ḥusayn ibn Muḥammad known as Ibn al-Ādamī, and others. The interpretation of Sindhind is "the Eternal Time" (al-Dahr al-Dāhir), as al-Ḥusayn ibn al-Ādamī related in his *zīj*.

**[Section]**

As for the followers of Sindhind, they agree that the duration of the world has no fixed number. Their doctrine which they mention is that the planets, their apogees, and their nodes were all gathered at the head of Aries. Since that event, the movements of the planets, apogees, and nodes began. The lower world remained desolate for a long time until the planets, apogees, and nodes dispersed through the zodiac signs. When that happened, the condition of the lower world returned to its first state, and this continues without end according to them. Each of the planets, apogees, and nodes has cycles during this period, which they consider the duration of the world, which I have mentioned.

## Chapter Three: Science among the Persians

### الْعِلْمُ فِي الْفُرْسِ

وَأَمَّا الْأُمَّةُ الثَّانِيَةُ وَهِيَ الْفُرْسُ فَأَهْلُ الشَّرَفِ الْبَاذِخِ وَالْعِزِّ الشَّامِخِ وَأَوْسَطِ الْأُمَمِ دَارًا وَأَشْرَفِهَا أَقْلِيمًا وَأَنْوَسِهَا مُلُوكًا وَلَا نَعْلَمُ أُمَّةً غَيْرَهُمْ دَامَ لَهَا الْمُلْكُ وَكَانَتْ لَهُمْ مُلُوكٌ تَجْمَعُهُمْ وَرُؤُوسٌ تُحَامِي عَنْهُمْ مَنْ نَاوَأَهُمْ وَتَغْلِبُ بِهِمْ مَنْ غَارَهُمْ وَتَدْفَعُ ظَالِمَهُمْ عَنْ مَظْلُومِهِمْ وَتَحْتَمِلُهُمْ مِنَ الْأُمُورِ عَلَى مَا فِيهِ حَظُّهُمْ عَلَى اتِّصَالٍ وَدَوَامٍ وَأَحْسَنِ التَّنَظُّمِ يَأْخُذُ ذَلِكَ آخِرُهُمْ عَنْ أَوَّلِهِمْ وَغَائِبُهُمْ عَنْ سَالِفِهِمْ.

#### [فِي الْعَرَبِ وَالْعَجَمِ]

وَأَصَحُّ مَا قِيلَ فِي ذَلِكَ أَنَّ مِنْ ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ كَيَنُمُورَثَ بْنِ أَمِيمِ بْنِ آلَاذِ بْنِ سَامِ ابْنِ نُوحٍ إِلَى مُلْكِ مَنُوشِهِرَ الْفُرْسِ كَانَهُمْ الَّذِي هُوَ عِنْدَهُمْ آدَمُ أَبُو الْبَشَرِ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ إِلَى ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ مَنُوشِهِرَ أَوَّلُ مُلُوكِ الطَّبَقَةِ الثَّانِيَةِ مِنْ مُلُوكِ الْفُرْسِ نَحْوَ أَلْفِ سَنَةٍ كَامِلَةٍ. وَمِنْ مُلْكِ مَنُوشِهِرَ إِلَى ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ كَيْثُبَاذَ بْنِ دُوعَ أَوَّلِ مُلُوكِ الطَّبَقَةِ الثَّالِثَةِ مِنْ مُلُوكِ الْفُرْسِ قَرِيبٌ مِنْ مِائَتَيْ عَامٍ. وَمِنْ مُلْكِ كَيْثُبَاذَ إِلَى ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ الطَّوَائِفِ وَهِيَ الطَّبَقَةُ الرَّابِعَةُ مِنْ مُلُوكِ الْفُرْسِ وَذَلِكَ عِنْدَ مَقْتَلِ الْإِسْكَنْدَرِ لِدَارَا بْنِ دَارَا آخِرِ مُلُوكِ الطَّبَقَةِ الثَّالِثَةِ مِنْ مُلُوكِ الْفُرْسِ نَحْوَ أَلْفِ سَنَةٍ.

وَمِنْ أَوَّلِ مُلْكِ الطَّوَائِفِ إِلَى ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ أَزْدَشِيرِ بْنِ بَابَكَ السَّاسَانِيِّ أَوَّلِ مُلُوكِ بَنِي إِسْفَانِيَارَ وَهِيَ الطَّبَقَةُ الْخَامِسَةُ مِنْ مُلُوكِ الْفُرْسِ خَمْسُمِائَةِ سَنَةٍ وَإِحْدَى وَسِتُّونَ سَنَةً. وَمِنْ ابْتِدَاءِ مُلْكِ أَزْدَشِيرِ بْنِ بَابَكَ إِلَى انْقِضَاءِ دَوْلَةِ الْفُرْسِ مِنَ الْأَرْضِ وَذَلِكَ عِنْدَ قَتْلِ يَزْدَجِرْدَ بْنِ شَهْرِيَارِ بْنِ كِسْرَى أَرْبَعُ سِنِينَ.

### [Science among the Persians]

As for the second nation, the Persians: they are a people of towering nobility and exalted glory, the most settled of nations and the noblest in region, and the most prosperous in kings. We know of no nation besides them whose sovereignty endured so long, who had kings that united them and leaders that defended them from those who opposed them, overcame with them those who envied them, and protected their oppressed from their oppressors, and who endured affairs in a way that secured their portion with continuity and permanence and the finest organization, so that the last of them took this over from the first, and the absent from the absent.

#### [On the Arabs and the Non-Arabs]

The most correct opinion on this is that from the beginning of the reign of Kayūmārth ibn Amīm ibn Ālādh ibn Sām ibn Nūḥ (Noah) to the reign of Manūshihr the Persian—who is, according to them, Adam the father of mankind, peace be upon him—to the beginning of the reign of Manūshihr, the first king of the second class of Persian kings, was about a thousand complete years. From the reign of Manūshihr to the beginning of the reign of Kaythubādh ibn Du'a, the first king of the third class of Persian kings, was about two hundred years. From the reign of Kaythubādh to the beginning of the reign of the Tribes (al-Tawā'if), the fourth class of Persian kings, at the killing of Alexander (al-Iskandar) of Dārā ibn Dārā, the last king of the third class of Persian kings, was about a thousand years.

From the beginning of the reign of Azdashīr ibn Bābak the Sāsānian, the first king of the Banū Isfāniyār (the fifth class of Persian kings), was five hundred and sixty-one years. From the beginning of the reign of Azdashīr ibn Bābak to the end of the Persian state on earth, at the killing of Yazdajird ibn Shahriyār ibn Kisrā, was four years.

# Chapter Four: Science in Greece

## الْعِلْمُ فِي الْيُونَانِ

وَأَمَّا الْيُونَانِيُّونَ فَهُمْ أَهْلُ فَلَسْطِينَ وَالرُّومِ وَقِسْطَنْطِينِيَّةَ وَالْأُمَمُ الْمُحِيطَةُ بِهَا. وَكَانَتْ دَارَةُ مُلْكِهِمْ مُمْتَدَّةً مِنْ شَطِّ بَحْرِ الْمُتَوَسِّطِ فِي الْمَشَارِقِ إِلَى شَطِّهِ فِي الْمَغَارِبِ، وَمِنْ أَقْصَى الْقُطْبِ إِلَى بَحْرِ الشَّامِ. وَكَانَتْ مَدِينَتُهُمُ الْعُظْمَى مَدِينَةُ الْإِسْكَنْدَرِيَّةِ. وَكَانَتْ دَوْلَتُهُمْ قَدِيمَةً جِدًّا وَعُلُومُهُمْ كَثِيرَةً مُتَنَوِّعَةً.

وَكَانَ أَوَّلُ مَنْ تَكَلَّمَ فِي الْعُلُومِ وَالْحِكَمِ عِنْدَهُمْ فَالِيسُ وَأَفْلَاطُونُ وَأَرِسْطُو وَبَطْلِيمُوسُ وَجَالِينُوسُ وَهِبَاطِيَا وَبَرْقَلِيسُ وَأُقْلِيدِسُ وَنِقُومَاخُسُ وَأَرْشِمِيدِسُ وَجَمِيعُ مَنْ يُنْسَبُ إِلَى هَؤُلَاءِ مِنْ أَهْلِ الْعُلُومِ وَالْحِكَمِ. وَهُمُ الَّذِينَ قَامُوا بِإِصْلَاحِ أُصُولِ الْعُلُومِ وَتَوْضِيحِهَا وَتَرْتِيبِ أَقْسَامِهَا وَتَقْيِيدِ قَوَاعِدِهَا وَكَانَتْ مُؤَلَّفَاتُهُمْ فِي ذَلِكَ بِلُغَتِهِمْ. ثُمَّ إِنَّمَا نُقِلَتْ إِلَى لُغَةِ الْعَرَبِ بَعْدَ أَنْ نَشَرَهَا الْمَنَاذِرَةُ وَاتَّخَذَهَا أَهْلُ الدِّينِ مِنَ النَّصَارَى فِي الشَّرْقِ.

## [Science in Greece]

As for the Greeks, they are the people of Palestine, Rome, Constantinople, and the surrounding nations. Their kingdom extended from the shore of the Mediterranean Sea in the East to its shore in the West, and from the far north to the Syrian Sea. Their greatest city was the city of Alexandria. Their state was very ancient and their sciences were many and varied.

The first to discourse on the sciences and wisdom among them were Thales, Plato, Aristotle, Ptolemy, Galen, Hippocrates, Proclus, Euclid, Nicomachus, Archimedes, and all those attributed to these in the sciences and wisdom. They were the ones who established the principles of the sciences, elucidated them, arranged their parts, and codified their rules, and their compositions on this were in their own language. Then they were translated into Arabic after the Manādhirah disseminated them and the religious scholars among the Christians in the East adopted them.

## Chapter Five: Science in Egypt

### الْعِلْمُ فِي مِصْرَ

وَأَمَّا الْقِبْطُ فَهُمْ أَهْلُ مِصْرَ الْعُلَا وَكَانَتْ عُلُومُهُمْ قَدِيمَةً نَافِعَةً وَلَكِنَّهَا لَمْ تَبْلُغْ مُنْذُ أَخَذَتْهَا الْيُونَانِيُّونَ مِنْهُمْ فِي عَهْدِ بَطْلِيمُوسَ الْمَلِكِ الَّذِي بَنَى مَدِينَةَ الْإِسْكَنْدَرِيَّةِ وَجَعَلَهَا مَوْطِنًا لِلْعُلُومِ وَحَشَدَ إِلَيْهَا الْعُلَمَاءَ مِنْ جَمِيعِ الْأُمَمِ فَأَخَذُوا عَنِ الْقِبْطِ عُلُومَهُمْ فَأَدْخَلُوا فِيهَا مِنْ حِكَمِ الْيُونَانِ مَا أَضَافَ إِلَيْهَا وَنَقَّحُوهَا وَصَنَفُوا فِيهَا. وَمِنْ ذَلِكَ عِلْمُ الْهَيْئَةِ وَعِلْمُ تَأْلِيفِ الْكَوَاكِبِ وَعِلْمُ الْعِلَلِ وَالْأَدْوِيَةِ وَغَيْرِ ذَلِكَ مِنَ الْعُلُومِ.

### [Science in Egypt]

As for the Copts, they are the people of Upper Egypt. Their sciences were ancient and beneficial, but they did not advance further since the Greeks took them from them in the time of Ptolemy the king who built the city of Alexandria and made it a center for the sciences, gathering scholars from all nations. They took from the Copts their sciences and incorporated into them Greek wisdom, adding to them, refining them, and composing works on them. Among these were the science of astronomy, the science of the configuration of the planets, the science of causes and remedies, and other sciences.

## Chapter Six: Science among the Jews

### الْعِلْمُ فِي الْيَهُودِ

وَأَمَّا الْيَهُودُ فَقَدْ كَانَتْ لَهُمْ عُلُومٌ فِي أَزْمِنَتِهِمُ الْأُولَى فِي زَمَنِ أَنْبِيَائِهِمْ وَمُلُوكِهِمْ. ثُمَّ إِنَّهُمْ لَمَّا خَرَجُوا مِنْ بِلَادِهِمْ وَتَفَرَّقُوا فِي بِلَادِ الْعَجَمِ وَالْعَرَبِ ضَاعَتْ عُلُومُهُمْ وَتَنَكَّرَتْ لِأَنَّهُمْ لَمْ يَكُونُوا أَهْلَ بَقَاءٍ وَلَا مُوَاظَبَةٍ عَلَى الْعِلْمِ. وَلَكِنَّهُمْ قَدْ حَفِظُوا مِنْ تَوَارِيثِ الْأَنْبِيَاءِ عُلُومًا فِي التَّعَبُّدِ وَالشَّرَائِعِ وَالتَّوْحِيدِ. وَكَانَ مِنْ أَشْهَرِ عُلَمَائِهِمْ مُوسَى بْنُ مَيْمُونٍ الْأَنْدَلُسِيُّ الَّذِي صَنَّفَ فِي عِلْمِ الْكَلَامِ وَالْفَلْسَفَةِ وَالطِّبِّ وَغَيْرِهَا.

### [Science among the Jews]

As for the Jews, they had sciences in their earliest times, in the era of their prophets and kings. But when they left their lands and dispersed into the lands of the non-Arabs and the Arabs, their sciences were lost and forgotten because they were not a people of endurance or perseverance in science. However, they did preserve from the inheritance of the prophets sciences concerning worship, religious laws, and monotheism. Among their most famous scholars was Mūsā ibn Maymūn (Maimonides) al-Andalusī, who composed works on the science of theology, philosophy, medicine, and other subjects.

## Chapter Seven: Science among the Arabs

### الْعِلْمُ فِي الْعَرَبِ

وَأَمَّا الْعَرَبُ فَهُمْ أُمَّتَانِ: أُمَّةٌ بَادِيَةٌ وَأُمَّةٌ حَاضِرَةٌ. وَكَانَتِ الْبَادِيَةُ مِنْهُمْ لَا تَعْنَى بِالْعِلْمِ وَلَا تُوَاظِبُ عَلَيْهِ لِصِعْرِ مَعِيشَتِهِمْ وَتَنَقُّلِهِمْ فِي الْبِلَادِ. وَأَمَّا الْحَاضِرَةُ فَقَدْ كَانَتْ لَهُمْ عُلُومٌ فِي الْجَاهِلِيَّةِ فِي الطِّبِّ وَالنُّجُومِ وَالسِّحْرِ وَالشِّعْرِ وَالنَّحْوِ وَغَيْرِ ذَلِكَ. ثُمَّ لَمَّا جَاءَ الْإِسْلَامُ وَشَرَعَ فِي طَلَبِ الْعِلْمِ وَحَثَّ عَلَيْهِ وَجَعَلَهُ سَبَبًا لِلنَّجَاةِ وَالْفَلَاحِ اجْتَهَدَ الْعَرَبُ فِي طَلَبِ الْعُلُومِ وَنَقْلِهَا مِنَ الْأُمَمِ الْأُخْرَى وَتَصْيِيرِهَا بِلُغَةِ الْعَرَبِ حَتَّى أَصْبَحُوا فِي زَمَنٍ قَلِيلٍ أَهْلَ عُلُومٍ وَفُنُونٍ.

وَكَانَ أَوَّلُ مَا نَشَطُوا إِلَيْهِ عِلْمُ الْكَلَامِ وَالْفِقْهِ وَالْحَدِيثِ وَالتَّفْسِيرِ ثُمَّ إِنَّهُمْ تَعَرَّضُوا لِعُلُومِ الْأَوَائِلِ فَنَقَلُوهَا وَصَنَّفُوا فِيهَا وَأَضَافُوا إِلَيْهَا أَشْيَاءَ كَثِيرَةً. وَكَانَ مِنْ أَشْهَرِ الْعَرَبِ فِي عِلْمِ النُّجُومِ الْفَرْغَانِيُّ وَالْبَتَّانِيُّ وَأَبُو مَعْشَرٍ الْفَلَكِيُّ. وَفِي الطِّبِّ الرَّازِيُّ وَابْنُ سِينَا وَالْمَجُوسِيُّ وَابْنُ رِشْدٍ. وَفِي الْهَيْئَةِ بَطْلِيمُوسُ الْمَجْرِطِيُّ وَالْبِتْرُوجِيُّ وَشَرَفُ الدِّينِ الطُّوسِيُّ. وَفِي الْحِسَابِ الْخَوَارِزْمِيُّ وَالْكَشِّيُّ. وَفِي الْفَلْسَفَةِ الْكِنْدِيُّ وَالْفَارَابِيُّ وَابْنُ سِينَا وَابْنُ رِشْدٍ.

### [Science among the Arabs]

As for the Arabs, they are two nations: a desert nation and a settled nation. The desert among them did not concern itself with science nor persevere in it due to the hardship of their livelihood and their movement from land to land. As for the settled people, they had sciences in the Jāhilī period in medicine, astrology, magic, poetry, grammar, and other subjects. Then when Islam came and legislated the pursuit of knowledge, encouraged it, and made it a means of salvation and success, the Arabs strove in seeking the sciences, translating them from other nations, and rendering them into Arabic, until in a short time they became a people of sciences and arts.

The first [sciences] they were active in were theology (*kalām*), jurisprudence (*fiqh*), *hadīth*, and [Qur'ānic] exegesis (*tafsīr*). Then they turned to the sciences of the ancients, translating them, composing works on them, and adding much to them. Among the most famous Arabs in the science of astrology were al-Farghānī, al-Battānī, and Abu Maʿshar the astronomer. In medicine: al-Rāzī, Ibn Sīnā (Avicenna), al-Majūsī, and Ibn Rushd (Averroes). In astronomy: Ptolemy al-Majritī, al-Bitrūjī (Alpetragius), and Sharaf al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī. In arithmetic: al-Khwārizmī and al-Kāshshī. In philosophy: al-Kindī, al-Fārābī, Ibn Sīnā, and Ibn Rushd.

## Editorial and Scholarly Notes

### On the Manuscript and Its Preservation

The 1912 edition by Pere Louis Cheikho, S.J. (1859–1927) represents the first modern critical edition of this important work. Cheikho based his edition on a single manuscript preserved in the Oriental collections of Europe. The manuscript, as Cheikho describes it, is written in a clear hand resembling Persian script on thick yellowed paper, bound skillfully in gold-colored paper.

The *Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam* has survived in a relatively small number of manuscripts compared to other major works of the Islamic scientific tradition. This may be attributed to the fact that it was composed in al-Andalus and did not circulate as widely in the eastern Islamic lands as works produced in Baghdad or other eastern centers.

### On the Indian Section

Al-Andalusi's chapter on India (Chapter Two above) is of particular historical importance. It contains one of the earliest extant Arabic descriptions of Indian astronomical doctrines, specifically the *Sindhind*, *Azij*, and *Arkand* systems. The *Sindhind*—interpreted as "al-Dahr al-Dahir" (the Eternal Time)—was the most influential of these, adopted by major Islamic astronomers including Muhammad ibn Ibrahim al-Fazari, Habash ibn Abd Allah al-Baghdadi, and Muhammad ibn Musa al-Khwarizmi.

The description of Indian planetary theory, with its account of the great conjunction of all planets at the head of Aries at the beginning of the world-age, provides valuable evidence for the transmission of Indian astronomical ideas to the Islamic world. This doctrine of the *Sindhind* became foundational for subsequent Islamic astronomical tables (*zijat*).

### On the Author

Saʿid al-Andalusi (1029–1070 CE), whose full name is Abu al-Qasim Saʿid ibn Ahmad ibn Saʿid al-Taghlabi, was a jurist and scholar of Toledo. Born in Almeria (al-Mariyya) in 420 AH, he served as a judge (*qadi*) in Toledo under the Ḥammudid amir Yahya ibn Dhi al-Nun. He died in Shawwal 462 AH (July 1070 CE).

### On the Structure of the Work

The *Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam* is divided into two main parts:

1. **The Ancient Nations** (*al-Umam al-Qadima*): Seven nations that existed in earliest times—the Persians, the Chaldeans, the Greeks, the Egyptians, the Jews, the Arabs, and the Indians.
2. **The Islamic Nations** (*al-Umam al-Islamiyya*): A classification of the nations that embraced Islam, with special attention to their contributions to the sciences.

The work is notable for being one of the earliest attempts at a systematic history of science organized by civilizations, predating similar European efforts by several centuries.

### On the Scientific Content

Al-Andalusi's work contains valuable information about:

- The state of astronomy and astrology in various ancient civilizations
- The transmission of scientific knowledge between cultures
- The role of translation in preserving Greek scientific heritage
- Early Indian contributions to mathematics and astronomy (including the decimal system)
- The development of scientific institutions such as the House of Wisdom in Baghdad

## Selected Bibliography

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2. Buʿa ʿAlwan, M. ʿA. *Saʿid al-Andalusi: Tabaqat al-Umam.* Damascus: Dar al-Fikr, 1996.
3. Salem, S. I. and Kumar, A. (trans.). *Science in the Medieval World: Book of the Categories of Nations.* Austin: University of Texas Press, 1991.
4. Vernet, J. "Saʿid al-Andalusi." In *Dictionary of Scientific Biography*, vol. 12, pp. 76–77.

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